

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 165

Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1958-1966

Coverage Date: 1958-1966

Place Coverage: G/Wi, Ghanzi District, Botswana

Section Title(S): Household Relationships

Children's lifetime attitudes toward their parents were summed up by an adult informant talking of his father and mother: "I love them and I fear [respect] them as I do no others and will always obey them because they made me." Although parents are a source of comfort, food, affection, and security, they are in the avoidance/respect category of kin. From the time the child is considered a responsible being, the physical and social person of the parent is treated with great respect.

[593](#)
[Family Relationships](#)

[602](#)
[Kin Relationships](#)

Sibling relationships. The gap of 4 or more years between births puts the elder child close to the age of assuming responsibility by the time the younger is born. By the time the baby has learned to walk, the elder sibling is old enough to be of considerable help in caring for him or her. When the stage is reached at which the child joins a play group, the older sibling will have a special responsibility, particularly when the household is in winter isolation. In the case of same-sex siblings, a good deal of training in techniques of subsistence is in the older brother's or sister's hands. In exercising responsibility, the elder sibling has no individual authority but vicariously invokes that of the parents by delegation, that is, falls back on them to validate his instructions. Consistent with this vicarious authority, the relationship between same-sex siblings before the younger attains independent status is a mixture of joking and respect. The personality of the elder is not an object of respect, but his or her instructions are obeyed. In return, the younger sibling, under the tutorship of the elder, depends on the latter for help, material items, and security. The typical relationship between same-sex siblings is one of affection and great trust. Relationships between siblings tend to be dyadic, as the eldest brother or sister will be married and out of the household by the time the third child is able to distinguish individual identities, leaving only the middle and youngest child together in the household while the last grows up. That is to say, there

[593](#)
[Family Relationships](#)

[602](#)
[Kin Relationships](#)

[855](#)
[Child Care](#)

[857](#)
[Childhood Activities](#)

[866](#)
[Independence Training](#)

are usually much closer bonds between first and second and between second and third than there are between the first and third children.

The behavioral inhibitions imposed by the brother-sister respect/avoidance etiquette reduce the extent and frequency of interaction  166 between opposite-sex siblings and place greater social distance between them than exists between a pair of brothers or sisters. An elder sister is closer to a young brother than an elder brother is to his younger sister. Because they learn many of their roles from their mothers, girls spend more time with them than do boys. An elder sister, therefore, has a greater share in the upbringing of a younger brother. The young boy is likely to still be in the household when his elder sister marries. At this stage her identity as a married woman reinforces the social distance of the avoidance/respect category and the young brother has no place with his sister and her husband. A junior sister, by contrast, is a joking partner of both the young spouses and spends a good deal of time with them, reinforcing the bond of same-sex siblinghood. Being the classificatory wife of her brother-in-law facilitates emotional identification with the elder sister; her tender age obviates possible strains of jealousy and the relationship between sisters is very close indeed. Brothers develop emotional interdependence in the play group and in the period of winter isolation when the elder plays his part in the younger boy's long process of learning to be a hunter. Their relationship is further stabilized by the prospect of possibly living out their adult lives in the same band, whereas sisters are more likely to be parted and to set up their respective neolocal households in different bands.

593

Family Relationships

602

Kin Relationships

868

Transmission Of Skills

Human Relations Area Files

*755 Prospect Street**New Haven, CT 06511*General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.eduIssues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)